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Ticket, ticket! Bus drivers waiting at the bus terminus in Koyambedu deciding which song to play. JOHAN SATYADAS



Now playing:

Ilaiyaraaja

Why does every mofussil bus driver in Tamil Nadu inevitably gravitate towards Ilaiyaraaja's music? We find out

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“Vellore!”
“Kanchipuram!”
“Pondicherry, Pondicherry, Pondicherry!”

The spirited meter that conductors use to beckon impatient passengers to their buses at the Chennai Mofussil Bus Terminus (CMBT) in Koyambedu is of a certain timeless disposition.

“Arani ah? Go to platform 2,” announces Superintendent V Dhanasekaran, ensuring that buses do not leave the stand empty. The call was the same before CMBT was established here in 2002. It will remain the same if ever the location shifts, he says. Quantum tunnels often possess this quality.

R Dillibabu, a driver who has been listening to his conductor's call for two decades now, says that there is one other wormhole similar to that of the boarding announcement for his bus travelling from Chennai to Kanchipuram.

“For 25 years now, the first song that is played on the bus' speaker is a *saami paatu* (invocation). What follows is a medley of songs by Ilaiyaraaja. I love his music and have a playlist of his songs on our music system. There are at least 100 that play on loop,” he says.

Dillibabu is one of several hundred drivers in Tamil Nadu that find comfort in the familiarity of Raaja. Anyone who has travelled in mofussil buses transporting people through routes that zoom past beaches, fields, hills and plains, will tell you that the majority of the songs that play on speakers are unmistakably by the Tamil composer.

Life may have drastically changed. Yet, the town bus playlist full of melodies from the Tamil countryside, speaking of innocent first love, heartbreak, friendship, maternal love, and the vast Tamil landscape, holds a steady permanence. It helps that Ilaiyaraaja's expansive repertoire of over 8,000 songs composed over 50 years since the release of his first

album *Annakili*, covers nearly every range of emotion and has a string of mellifluous voices attached to them.

Over the last seven years, transport authorities have disallowed drivers from playing songs in their buses, citing distraction. Only private operators are permitted to play songs on their now up-to-date speaker sets. Yet, some drivers and conductors are given permission to play songs at a cost of ₹3 a song, based on requests. Many drivers, particularly the ones operating outside of Chennai, persist and play the songs for both themselves and the passengers.

With Raaja, several generations have been transported not just to

their destinations, but to the halcyon days, when life seemed visibly different.

Dillibabu makes eight trips a day between Kanchipuram and the city; he can sometimes feel age catching up. “But when I listen to a song by Raaja, everything becomes calm. I compulsorily play ‘Senthazham Poovil’ at least once each night. Everything changes when that song comes on,” he says.

Some drivers like Dillibabu seem to have accumulated a set of fans for their playlists. M Vinoth, who rides his bus between Chennai, Vandavasi, Tiruvannamalai, and Cheyyur, has a playlist of 500 songs that he begins playing early in the morning. His bus, which usually departs from Koyambedu at 8am, not only invites regulars but also new travellers who enter the bus thanks to his playlist. “For the working man, Raaja is solace. He is there for our happy days. More importantly though, he is there for all our sad times,” he says.

B Kumaresan, a conductor whose bus plies between Cheyyur in Chengalpattu and Chennai, says that at night, passengers sometimes fight for seats. However, when Ilaiyaraaja songs come on, the scuffle quickly stills. “There is something about him,” he says. Kumaresan has a certain penchant for love songs and songs about mothers. “I had a love marriage and my wife and I often listen to his songs together. Maybe that is why I am so attached to his music,” he says.

On some occasions, it has been observed that bus drivers play AI remixes of old songs. M Paneerselvam, a bus driver who has been driving for 19 years, says that he loves Raaja's latest ‘Kaatumalli’ but adds that since his bus plies between Puducherry and Chennai, a mixed crowd comes onboard. To appease the older passengers and the younglings, these AI mixes which are likely flouting copyright laws, are played nevertheless.

The Ultimate Ilaiyaraaja Town Bus Playlist

A curation of songs sourced from drivers in Tamil Nadu that play in their buses

■ ‘Senthazham Poovil’ from Mullum Malarum

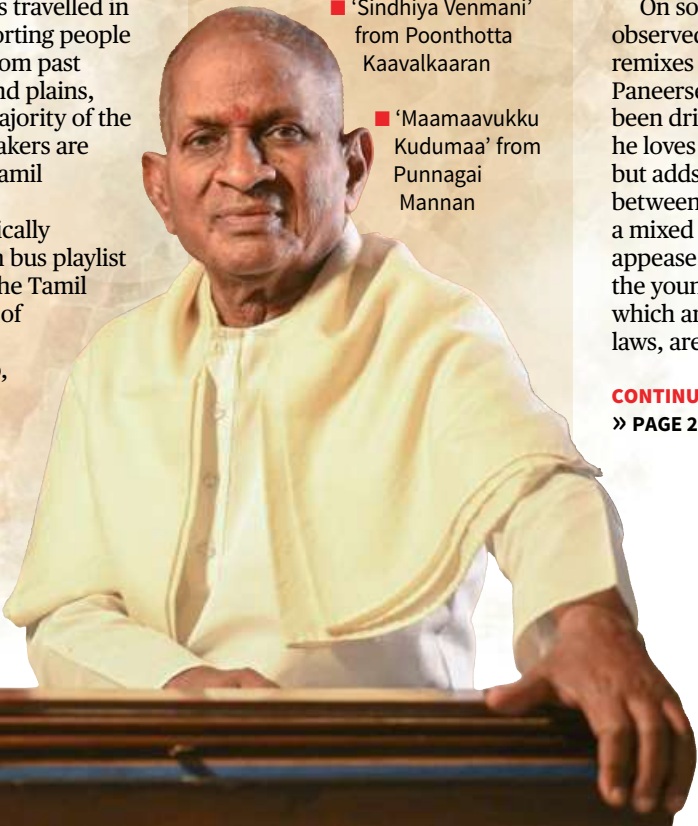
■ ‘Indha Maan’ from Karakattakkaran

■ ‘Idhayam Oru Kovil’ from Idaya Kovil

■ ‘Ennai Thottu Alli Konda’ from Unna Nenachen Pattu Padichen

■ ‘Sindhya Venmani’ from Poonthotta Kaavalkaaran

■ ‘Maamaavukku Kudumaa’ from Punnaigai Mannan



Scan the QR code to listen to the full playlist.



TV SERIAL
INNUMA MUDIYALA?

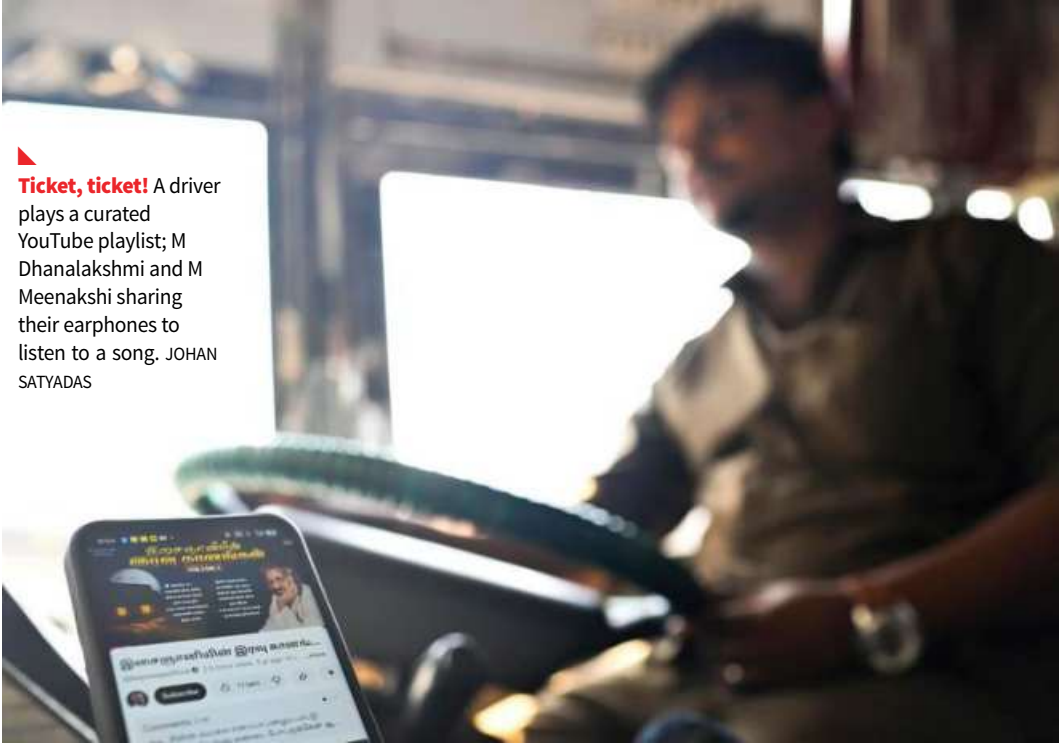


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Ticket, ticket! A driver plays a curated YouTube playlist; M Dhanalakshmi and M Meenakshi sharing their earphones to listen to a song. JOHAN SATYADAS

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Many interviewees repeat that Raaja’s songs are great company for lonely long rides at night when the world around them sleeps. His melodies do not interfere with the driving and help them remain even-keeled despite their physically strenuous journeys. “It helps us stay wide awake, and allows restless passengers to relax and doze off,” says M Rajappan, a conductor from Puducherry who loves listening to all the songs from the 1985 film *Idaya Koil* including ‘Idayam Oru Koil’.

A dash of nostalgia
Writer-translator G Kuppuswamy who has authored *Kaalathai Isaitha*

Now playing: Ilayyaraaja

Kalaigann: Illaiyaraaja 80, a book of three essays on Ilayyaraaja (published by Kalachuvadu), jokingly recounts a trip from Tiruvannamalai (his workplace) to Arani (where his home is located), where a bus driver engaged in a heated exchange with another, yelling at the top of his lungs. “The man was exploding with expletives when the song

‘Ennai Thottu Alli Konda’ came on. His demeanour completely changed. Suddenly, he was asking a woman carrying a heavy bag to keep it aside and sit down comfortably. He seemed like a different man,” he recounts.

The writer who has met the composer, says that drivers may say that Raaja helps them stay up, but that only scratches the surface. “Talking to a driver



M VINOTH
Bus driver



Crafted for summer

Popsicle returns this summer with a pop-up featuring fashion, jewellery, kidswear, home décor and artisanal food from homegrown brands. Conceptualised by Selvi Mahesh and Dr Rashmi Chellappa, the event will also feature skincare and perfume brands. Some Chennai brands at the exhibit include Looms & Lores, Shilpa Vummiti, House of Gaia, Threads Vastra and Amrit Design House. @The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah. On May 30 between 10am and 8pm. Entry is free.

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A retired government officer in Sri Lanka, Saman Athaudahetti is well known in the island’s political, literary, and cultural circles for his many avatars – as adviser to former President Ranil Wickremesinghe, additional secretary when Wickremesinghe was Premier, and as television presenter, author, and lyricist. Despite several official visits and holiday trips to India, it is only post-retirement that he was able to earmark time for this dream.

“I must have gone to India about 30 to 40 times, mostly for work. I did manage to do a few holiday trips, and I had the chance to travel by train...I found it simply amazing,” he says, speaking to *The Hindu* in Colombo. Like India, Sri Lanka’s own railway network was built during British colonial rule. Labourers from South India, brought to the island to work on tea plantations (or Malaiyaha Tamils as they are identified today), helped build it. But the extent of the Indian railway network and its reach to remote parts of the country, have long fascinated Athaudahetti, so much so that he decided to write a book on the theme, following his other travelogues.

India-Sri Lanka Foundation, a trust fund setup by the governments of the two countries to back projects aimed at enhancing relations between the nations, offered to support Athaudahetti’s book project. “The book will first be published in Sinhala and possibly translated to English later. The idea is to capture the expanse of the Indian Railways, so I travelled through 17 states and nine railway zones, covering very different geographies, cities, and experiences,” he says. In addition to financial support, Indian authorities and a travel



A driver was exploding with expletives when the song ‘Ennai Thottu Alli Konda’ came on. His demeanour completely changed. He seemed like a different man

G KUPPUSWAMY
Author

who travels long distances is obviously distracting. However, music can be transformative. A pacy song may want them to go fast. Raaja’s music, particularly his melodies, retain a certain consistent sound. That goes a long way on a hard night,” he says.

T Dharmaraj, Professor and Head, Department of Folklore and Cultural Studies, Madurai Kamaraj University, who has written the book *Ilaiyaraajavai Varaitthal*, wishes to draw a metaphorical parallel between a bus being a vessel that transported one to a destination, and Raaja being a vessel that transports one to different planes. “Think about the themes in most of his songs. They all have a deeply nostalgic trait about them. The scenery around a traveller is constantly changing. One feels like they are still in movement despite having stopped sometimes. Ilayyaraaja’s songs are similar. They have allowed an entire generation to go back to a time they cannot access anymore,” he says.

Back at the bus terminus in Koyambedu, M Dhanalakshmi, and a group of five other women, are travelling to Vandavasi. These fans say that Raaja’s 1989 hit album from the film *Karakattakkaran* is their favourite. They even burst into a short-giggly rendition of the song ‘Maanguyile Poonkuyile’ from the film. “I am not sure of the lyrics but I think this is it,” says Meenakshi, singing coyly to the camera.

Conductor B Rajan Prabhu who walks past them turns to his much younger colleague who has just joined the job. “You 2K kids,” he sighs. “Will you ever know how precious this is.”

Sew far, sew good

From visible mending workshops and thrift pop-ups to conversations on textile waste, SustainabilATTI hopes to bring slow fashion conversations to the streets of Chennai

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If you have an older sibling, chances are you grew up wearing their hand-me-downs. While it may have felt unfair at times, there was also a certain thrill in inheriting clothes they had outgrown. Long before thrifting became trendy and sustainability turned into a buzzword, many Indian households were already practising conscious consumption in small, everyday ways.

That conversation around conscious consumption is now taking centre stage at SustainabilATTI, a day-long sustainable fashion festival. Organised by Kalaki Collective and Noolu Collective in collaboration with India Wasted Foundation and Atti Culture, the event brings together panel discussions, visible mending workshops, thrift pop-ups and live rap performances under one roof.

“Fast fashion is one of the most urgent crises of our time, but these conversations rarely reach people in a way that feels accessible or engaging. Through SustainabilATTI, we wanted to bring slow fashion conversations down to street level,” says Dhavalaya Sagar from Kalaki Collective. She says that the idea was not just to host another sustainability talk, but to create a space where people could actively participate. The event will



Stitch, please Patch work workshop conducted by Noolu Collective in Bengaluru previously. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

feature Vaanga Peslam, a panel discussion on textile waste and conscious fashion practices, followed by KathriCool, a beginner-friendly visible mending workshop where participants can bring damaged garments to repair. There will also be the Fashion Katchi, a market showcasing homegrown sustainable brands and thrift pop-ups. The evening will conclude with performances by independent rappers from Atti Culture, a Chennai-based independent music label.

For Pranati Vijay from Noolu Collective, the focus is equally on making sustainability feel practical rather than intimidating. “People don’t always recognise hyper-consumption as an issue. We wanted to create something where people can walk in, learn a skill and leave feeling like sustainability is actually accessible,” she says.

In the visible mending workshop KathriCool,

attendees are encouraged to bring garments that need repair. Participants will first learn basic stitching techniques before moving on to Sashiko, a Japanese visible mending method that uses embroidery-style stitching to repair tears, holes and worn-out sections in clothing. While sustainability-focussed events and fashion communities have steadily grown in cities like Bengaluru, Dhavalaya feels that Chennai’s conversations around slow fashion has largely remained scattered across smaller circles. Through SustainabilATTI, she hopes to spotlight the region’s own rich textile traditions and homegrown sustainable brands.

SustainabilATTI will be hosted at Quest, Besant Nagar, on May 30 from 2pm to 8pm. Tickets are priced at ₹250. Log on to Instagram page @kalakicollective for details and bookings.



Chugging along Saman Athaudahetti and his tryst with the Indian Railways. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

politely adds. Digitisation is another aspect that stood out. “Ticket checkers who would earlier carry those files are now using tabs. There are apps that give you all the information about schedules, PNR status, and the time of arrival. You can order food on these apps, and it’ll be delivered while you’re in the train. You can raise complaints, it’s quite amazing how technology has been integrated to this public transport service.” Vande Bharat trains are “impressive” and the launch of bullet trains connecting Mumbai and Ahmedabad, scheduled in 2027, will help the Indian Railways further its game, he notes.

An important takeaway from his experience is the “beauty of diversity”, Athaudahetti says, recalling the varied terrain, climate, people, languages, and food he encountered. “The food...oh my! just so many different cuisines and tastes,” he says. However, there was one meal that beat the rest. A home-cooked meal at Ledo station pointsman Raja Das’s home. “There was a major traffic jam in the town that day and we were racing against time to catch our next train. We did not have time to go find lunch. Raja Das invited us to his modest home nearby, and his mother and wife quickly cooked a meal just for us. They served us a sumptuous meal of rotis, rice, fish and vegetables quickly. It was truly delicious. I will never forget the family’s warmth and hospitality,” he says. Athaudahetti certainly has a lot to write about but “this is only the first leg”, the 68-year-old adds. “I have so much more to cover in the Indian Railways that I will need to go back!”

Changing tracks

Forty days and 24 trains crisscrossing India — that sums up Saman Athaudahetti’s February and March, as he chased his long-held dream of exploring this country through its railway network



agent helped him plan his visit, including the itinerary, logistics and his interviews with various officials. “Many of the Indian officials were incredibly helpful, especially Dinesh Sood [Senior Principal Private Secretary to the Member (Infrastructure), Railway Board]. The railway staff I met are like family now, sending me WhatsApp forwards and good morning greetings every day,” he says. Athaudahetti’s journey

covered well-known stations such as Ledo in Assam, the easternmost station in India; or Navapur, located on the Gujarat-Maharashtra State border. “The platform here is split between the two states, it is really interesting! I also went to Ghoom in Darjeeling, the highest railway station in India; Gorakhpur junction which has the second longest platform in the world; and Howrah, one of the busiest railway stations in the world,”

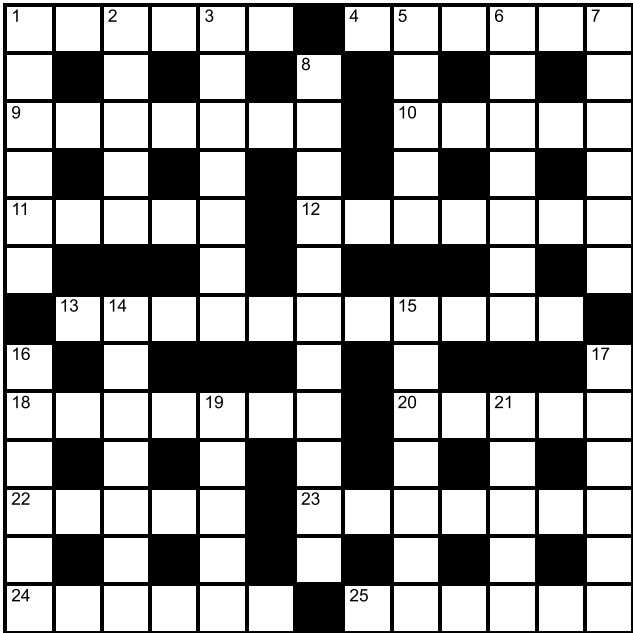
he says. He spoke to passengers, station masters, and other railway officials to record both, information and experiences of the Indian Railways. For company, he had his brother Asoka Athaudahetti, who helped visually document the journey.

Athaudahetti points to a marked improvement in facilities, coaches and in overall cleanliness, barring “some exceptions”, in the last 10 to 15 years. “You know, cleanliness depends on the passengers, it’s not only upto the railway authorities,” he



The railway staff I met are like family now, sending me WhatsApp forwards and good morning greetings every day

QUICK CROSSWORD #55 (Set by Doppelganger)

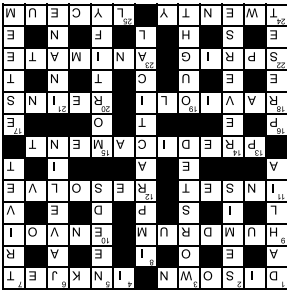


- Across**
1 Repudiate (6)
4 Type of printer (3-3)
9 Pedestrian (7)
10 Brief stanza at end of poem (5)
11 Implant (5)
12 Willpower (7)
13 Unpleasant situation (11)
18 Square pasta case (7)
20 Kidneys (5)
22 Young immature person (5)
23 Fill with life (7)
24 One score (6)
25 Meeting hall (6)
- Down**
1 Flower (6)
2 Halves (5)
3 Type of yarn (7)
5 Requires (5)
6 Metal-tipped spear (7)
7 Metal stand for vessels (6)
8 Not workable (11)
14 Backward (7)

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Solution No. 55



The actor talks about working with Suriya in *Karuppu* and getting over his fear of handling the language



WHO IS INDRANS?

- Known for his performances in films like *Aalorukkam*, *Home* and *Punjabi House*, Indrans is among Malayalam cinema's top character actor today.
- Starting as a costume designer before turning actor, Indrans evolved from comedy roles into award-winning performances marked by realism and emotional depth.
- While his performance in the recent *Karuppu* is being talked about, Indrans also appeared in a brief role in director Shankar's Tamil flick *Nanban* (the remake of *3 Idiots*), starring Vijay.

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There is no missing the smile in Indrans' voice as he talks about his role as Mattancherry Sukumaran in the blockbuster Suriya-starrer *Karuppu*. "Tamil is a language I have immense respect for. The same goes for the films and the industry. I have worked in Chennai during my costume designer days. However, I didn't stay for too long. I returned home, to Kerala!" he says, referring to his first major role in a Tamil film. *Karuppu*, directed by RJ Balaji, was a leap of faith for the actor, who has stuck to Malayalam films. He confesses to his many apprehensions about working in a film in Tamil, a language, he says, he was not sure he could do a film in.

"I simply did not have the courage." As he demurred, Balaji convinced him.

Using the language
"There was a language problem, in my mind, which has held me back from Tamil movies all these



years; then there were date issues as well for this film. But Balaji was persistent. He told me that he had written the role with me in mind. That it was not a Tamil character but a Malayalam-speaking person. That put my mind at ease. Another key factor was that I had watched Balaji's other films, and I liked them." That Balaji telling him not to worry about the language, to speak the Tamil he could and was comfortable in, meant a lot to him is evident from the way Indrans talks about it. "I was also worried about the performance because we have heard that the tempo is higher in Tamil films. There was nothing like that. Balaji told me to keep it simple, and present the

Actorspeak Indrans; (below) Suriya in *Karuppu*.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

character as I normally would." Indrans as the hapless Mattancherry Sukumaran trapped in a legal case and how the lawyers engaged by him bleed him financially dry is heartbreaking. Anagha Ravi is his daughter Binu Sukumaran. His portrayal has come in for praise. "I feel as heavy or light as a sheet of paper... floating high in the air with all the praise coming my way," he says, a tad bashfully. "I have not watched the film yet since I have been on the sets of *Kaalante Thangakudam*. I plan to catch up on the film over the next couple of days, hopefully." Then comes the inevitable question, the experience of acting with Suriya. Indrans confesses it was his first time meeting the actor, who has a huge fan following in Kerala. "Of course I was apprehensive about meeting him, seeing him up close. I was excited and anxious about it; being in the combination scenes with him. But when I finally met him, he was so nice to talk to and down-to-earth. He had no airs about him, he came and spoke to me. It was all very jolly! Balaji made everything comfortable. There was no pressure or stress on the sets. Suriya was patient in our combination scenes...he was like how he would be with a newcomer. Because in a sense I was one, in Tamil cinema." His first shot was the court scene, when Sukumaran and Binu land up at the court. "One of the first people I saw there was Arun Venjaramoodu, the production designer from Kerala, who went independent with the Malayalam film *Alamara*. Then there were so many Malayalis on the set, like Unnimaya, Sivada, and Swasika, apart from Anagha."

Although *Karuppu* is not his first Tamil film, it is his first with a considerable role. "I have been part of some Tamil films. Like *Nanban* in which I had a small role, which I did because of my greed – I wanted to be in a film by Shankar sir." Indrans' next Tamil project is Rajkumar Periasamy's film, which has Mammooty and Dhanush. He says one of the reasons he took on the project was Mammooty told him it was a good one. "I have been getting offers in Tamil but I could not accept them because of my commitments here. I, obviously, cannot abandon Malayalam movies," he says.

Celluloid memories

Cinematographer R Rathnavelu on why some portions of *Peddi* were shot on film negative

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Rathnavelu, one of India's reputed cinematographers, is disarmingly warm during this interview at Hyderabad's Annapurna Studios Annexe. He has been finalising the post production for director Buchi Babu Sana's Telugu film *Peddi*, starring Ram Charan and Janhvi Kapoor, releasing on June 4. "*Peddi* is a mainstream commercial film that is also deeply emotional. I try to raise the bar with each of my films, and this one has been creatively satisfying," he says.

He has been a cinematographer for more than three decades. For the unversed, he was drawn to cinema after watching director Mani Ratnam and cinematographer PC Sreeram's early films. After graduating in Physics, Rathnavelu enrolled in the Madras Film Institute and later assisted cinematographer Rajiv Menon for Mani Ratnam's *Bombay*. Rathnavelu's association with Buchi Babu Sana began when the latter was in the writing team of director Sukumar's *1-Nenokkadine* and *Rangasthalam*, but the offer for *Peddi* came from Ram Charan. Rathnavelu recalls, "Charan called and said he wanted me for this film. Buchi Babu visited me in Chennai for a story narration and I was impressed. I choose a film only if I like the script. If I feel otherwise, I express my opinion. Rajinikanth sir appreciated me once when I told him upfront that I did not like an idea."

Vintage frames
Rathnavelu wanted to give *Peddi* a distinct look, veering away from the brown tone of *Rangasthalam*.

Let there be light
Ram Charan in *Peddi*; (above) Rathnavelu.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"*Peddi* narrates the protagonist's journey and his transformation through different stages. He works at a sugarcane factory near Vizianagaram and hails from a community that fights for its identity. I wanted a realistic texture for this story set in the 1980s and 90s. I decided to shoot one portion using film negative, and give a vintage look to the other portions shot on digital cameras to maintain synergy."

Rathnavelu's last work on film was Rajinikanth's *Endhiran* (*Robot*), directed by Shankar. For *Peddi*, Eastman Kodak film cans were imported. "Shooting on film calls for planning and discipline on the sets since you cannot waste film reel." The choice of shooting on film, Rathnavelu explains, was to achieve a grainy texture in contrast to the sharp, clinical digital frames. Rathnavelu adds that he used Vintage Cooke lenses for some portions. "I want to transport the audience to the '80s. In addition to costumes, lighting and locations, the blemishes and texture that these lenses provide also helps."

Sports and drama
In *Peddi*, Ram Charan plays "a crossover athlete", adept at cricket and wrestling. Rathnavelu reveals that two cricket matches – one during the day and another filmed under floodlights – will be among the highlights. "These visuals will differ from the wrestling portions, for which I used bodylighting techniques to highlight Charan's muscular physique. I like the visuals to convey the emotional crux of the story." Post *Peddi*, Rathnavelu is yet to decide his next move. He has nurtured directorial dreams for nearly a decade, though cinematography commitments have kept him occupied. But he hopes to direct soon.



Common lives

Kutti Revathy's new Tamil film *Vanji*, set in the 7th Century, was showcased in the Market section of the Cannes Film Festival

Prathap Nair

It's wheels up for the production schedule of Kutti Revathy's latest film, *Vanji*, but before she released it in India, she took it out for a spin on a global trip. She was in Cannes this week to show her film to potential distributors. A period piece shot across Gingee's archaeological sites, *Vanji* is a retelling of *Kundalakesi*, set in 7th-Century Tamil Nadu. The film stars Rukkumani Kumaraguruparan and Rajmohan Subramaniam in lead roles. Its songs are composed by TAS Thakkesi, with a background score by Tharun Sekar. Speaking on the sidelines of the festival on how the film came about, Revathy says, "I had long been drawn to the idea of placing a strong woman at the centre of a Tamil film, and Tamil literature offered me no shortage of such women. The challenge was choosing which story to tell."

Revathy, working with limited resources, decided to narrow her search for her subject even further by asking, which of these women lived ordinary, common people lives? "That question led me to *Kundalakesi*," she adds. "She is not royalty but a laywoman. The more I read of her, the more I understood that



her struggles and her transformations spoke directly to our present moment." According to her, *Kundalakesi*'s story of a woman confronting betrayal and choosing her own path bears all the hallmarks of a great story worth telling. "This is not an ancient story, this is a 'right now' story," she says. Film promotion remains a challenge for indie filmmakers, and at Cannes, Revathy had to take things into her own hands. She stood on the Palais festival grounds, in a gold-accented sari, her hair in a bun, flashing an optimistic smile and displaying the ink-blue poster of her film to invite the audience. Revathy and her producer attended the Cannes Market screenings, an opportunity for producers to

pay to rent screening venues to showcase their films in the hope of attracting prospective buyers and distributors. The filmmaker is of the opinion that the cultural impetus of transforming India's great literature is still lacking. "We still measure our films in crores of revenue. *Vanji* is my attempt to shift that conversation." For Revathy, the Cannes trip is a huge success. She screened the film on May 17 in the Market section of the festival. The film was already certified by the censor board in India last December. However, before the film releases in theatres in India, she plans to tour other film festivals like Busan and Toronto to show it to a global audience.

Going global
Kutti Revathy at Cannes Film Festival.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Long into the night

Harish Sridhar, a Chennai-based intellectual property lawyer and writer, has made a Tamil-English short film titled *Oru Naal Uravu*. Released recently on YouTube through AP International, the 40-minute slice-of-life drama follows two working individuals navigating their pasts with each other. Starring Krishna and Smruthi Mohankumar, the short features songs by Badhri Seshadri of 'Motta Maadi Music' fame. Inspired by 'Norwegian Wood' by The Beatles, *Oru Naal Uravu* explores aspects of modern dating.



What's Karthi upto?

Tamil actor Karthi's upcoming film, co-starring Meenakshi Chaudhary, has gone on floors. The Tamil-Telugu bilingual is directed by Kalyan Sundar (of *Mad* and *Mad Square* fame) and produced by Suryadevara Naga Vamsi of Sithara Entertainments. Notably, Karthi is awaiting the release of director PS Mithran's *Sardar 2* and is also working on *Marshall*, directed by Tamizh.

